



## **Terms of reference (ToRs)**

Expert Pool 1 TOR 1 Mission 16 of 2026

## **Provision of a pool of short-term experts to strengthen local authorities and Event Coordination**



**Project Title: Good Governance in Local Authorities**

**Country: Zimbabwe**

### **TOR for:**

Assignment ToR

Consultancy Services for the Design, Development and Deployment of a Mutoko RDC Website

Expert Pool 1 TOR 1 Mission 16

TOR Short-Term Mission

Date: 02/09/2026

**Good Governance in Local Authorities -Zimbabwe**

## **1. Context / Background**

The Project “Good Governance in Local Authorities (GGLA)” is jointly co-financed by the European Union (EU), Swiss Agency for Development Cooperation (SDC) and the German Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (BMZ) and implemented by Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ). The project duration is scheduled from April 2024 to June 2029.

The Objective of the project is enhanced efficiency, effectiveness, and inclusivity in the 20 targeted partner local authorities in the provision of social services. To achieve this, the project focusses on four main areas of support – (1) service delivery, (2) public financial management (3) support to councilors as well as (4) gender equality and inclusion. Furthermore, transparency, accountability, enhanced citizen participation and digitalization are key areas that will be mainstreamed across these four outputs.

The project addresses key capacity gaps in the mentioned areas of support strengthening the individual skills of specialists and managers through capacity building and by analyzing and improving processes, leveraging digital tools where possible.

### **Background**

In line with the Government of Zimbabwe’s E-Governance agenda and the principles of Good Governance for Local Authorities, Mutoko Rural District Council (RDC) seeks to enhance transparency, accountability and citizen participation through digital transformation.

Currently, Mutoko RDC has limited digital presence, resulting in restricted access to public information, inefficient communication with residents, and reduced citizen participation in governance processes. Information dissemination largely depends on manual and physical systems, which limits reach and effectiveness.

To address these challenges, Mutoko RDC intends to develop an official Council Website as a central platform for communication, transparency, and access to information.

## **2. Objectives of the Assignment**

### **Overall Objective**

To design, develop, and deploy an official website for Mutoko Rural District Council that serves as a centralized, accessible digital hub—enhancing good governance, promoting transparency, and improving public access to council services and information.

### **Specific Objectives**

- **Build a user-friendly council website:** Create an easy-to-use website for Mutoko Rural District Council that works smoothly on phones and computers, serving as the main digital home for all council information.
- **Simplify Public Digital Access to Information and Services:** Organize the website so community members can easily find public notices, By-laws, Policies, Strategic Plans, Full council meeting schedule, Council Minutes, Agendas, download forms, check council rates, and understand how to access local services.
- **Incorporate portals for public interaction with council:** Build dedicated sections to upload official reports, annual budgets, meeting records, and public documents so residents can stay informed about council decisions, can give feedback and report complaints
- **Local Economic Development & Investments module:** Build an easily accessible and user-friendly section to be used to highlight available investment opportunities and showcase successful local projects within the council area.
- **Train Local Staff for Long-Term Management:** Provide hands-on training to council staff so they can update text, upload news, and maintain the website on their own without needing outside help.

### 3. Scope of Work and Specific Tasks

The Short-Term Expert (STE) will be responsible for the design, development, deployment, and initial support of the website.

#### 3.1 System Design and Architecture

- Design a secure, scalable, and modular system architecture
- Define database structures using relational design principles
- Develop API-ready architecture for integrations
- Ensure compliance with security best practices (RBAC, encryption, audit logs)

#### 3.2 Website Development

The expert shall develop a dynamic Content Management System-based website with the following modules:

##### 3.2.1 Homepage with dynamic content and navigation

The Homepage will serve as the dynamic entry point of the Mutoko Rural District Council Website, guiding users to key services and information. The website administrator will have the ability to update slider images and homepage content as needed.

##### Homepage Functional Requirements

- The system shall provide:
- Dynamic image slider/carousel
- Quick-access Call To Action buttons:

- Bill payment / Online services
- Public notices
- Tenders
- Vacancies
- Contact directory
- Latest news preview (auto-fetch from news module)
- Featured announcements
- Optional performance counters:
- Projects completed
- Residents served
- Active tenders

### **3.2.2 Institutional Information module**

This section of the website will serve as a structured repository of key institutional details, ensuring residents and stakeholders can easily understand the council's mandate, vision, and organizational framework. The content will be organized into clear, accessible pages, including:

- About Us
- Mandate
- Vision & Mission
- Strategic Goals
- Organogram
- Ward Maps

To maintain flexibility and sustainability, the Website Administrator will be able to update each of these pages through the content management system without the need to edit code.

### **3.2.3 Leadership & Departments module**

This section of the website will highlight the leadership and administrative structure of Mutoko District, ensuring residents can easily identify and connect with their representatives and council officials. It will provide detailed information on:

- The Council Chairperson
- The Chief Executive Officer
- Councillors
- Heads of Departments
- Other relevant staff

To ensure accuracy and ease of updates, the Website Administrator will be able to modify this information directly through the content management system without the need to edit code.

### **3.2.4 Governance & Policy documentation repository**

This section of the website will serve as a centralized repository for key council documents, ensuring residents and stakeholders have easy access to important governance and policy information. It will provide structured pages for:

- By-laws
- Policies
- Strategic Plans
- Council Minutes
- Full Council Meeting Schedule
- Agendas

By consolidating these resources in one place, the platform will promote transparency and accountability, while allowing the Website Administrator to manage and update documents seamlessly through the content management system without the need for coding.

#### Functional Requirements

- Year-based grouping
- Version control
- Document replacement without deletion
- Download tracking
- Search & filter

### **3.2.5 Financial Transparency module**

To strengthen accountability and build trust with residents, the website will include a dedicated section for financial transparency. This area will provide structured and accessible publications of key financial information, including:

- Annual Budgets
- Audited Financial Statements
- Financial Reports
- Procurement Plans
- Awarded Tenders Register

By making these documents publicly available in a clear and organized format, the council will ensure that residents can easily track financial decisions and resource allocation.

### **3.2.6 News, Notices & Announcements module**

To keep residents consistently informed about council activities and updates, the website will feature a dedicated section for news, notices, and announcements. This module will ensure timely communication and transparency by allowing:

- The Web Administrator to publish new announcements
- The Web Administrator to edit or delete previously published announcements
- Scheduling of announcements for future publication

By providing these capabilities, the council can maintain an up-to-date information flow and ensure that important messages reach the community effectively

### Functional Requirements

- Publish scheduling
- Expiry logic
- Urgent alert banner
- Category tagging
- SEO metadata

### **3.2.7 Tenders & Procurement module**

To further enhance transparency and accountability, the website will include a dedicated section for tenders and procurement information. This module will ensure that residents, businesses, and stakeholders have open access to council procurement processes and outcomes. It will incorporate the following functional requirements:

### Functional Requirements

- Automatic status update after closing date
- Awarded contractor listing
- Calendar view (optional)
- Compliance reporting

### **3.2.8 Vacancies module**

To promote openness and provide equal opportunities, the website will feature a dedicated section for publishing council vacancies. This module will allow the Web Administrator to:

- Post new vacancies
- Edit existing vacancy listings
- Delete vacancies that are no longer available

By enabling these functions, the council can ensure that employment opportunities are communicated transparently and kept up to date for all residents and stakeholders.

### **3.2.9 Projects & Programmes module**

To showcase ongoing development initiatives and keep residents informed, the website will feature a dedicated section for council projects and programmes. This module will allow the Web Administrator to:

- Post new projects and programme details
- Edit existing information
- Delete outdated or completed entries

By providing these capabilities, the council can ensure that community members have up-to-date insights into local development efforts and progress

### **3.2.10 Investment & Tourism module**

To highlight economic potential and attract both local and external stakeholders, the website will include a dedicated section showcasing Mutoko District's, community programs, and local business opportunities (such as agriculture and mining) to attract partners and investors.

This module will allow the Web Administrator to:

- Post new investment and tourism opportunities
- Requirements for investment.
- Edit existing listings
- Delete outdated or inactive entries
- Post investment requirements

Module is supposed to allow potential investors to submit investment enquiries.

By maintaining this section, the council can promote Mutoko as a destination for growth and development, while ensuring that information remains current and accessible to residents, investors, and visitors.

### **3.2.11 Contact and communication module**

To make communication with the council simple and accessible, the website will include a dedicated section for contact information and location details. This module will display:

- Council Phone Numbers
- Official Facebook Page
- Email Address
- Physical Address with Google Map integration

By providing these details in a structured format, residents and stakeholders will be able to reach the council quickly and conveniently.

### **3.2.12 Legal & Compliance pages**

This section of the website will present the council's legal and compliance information, ensuring residents have access to important policies and regulatory guidelines. While the content will remain largely static, the Web Administrator must be able to update it easily through the content management system. The module will include pages such as:

- Privacy Policy
- Terms of Use
- Accessibility Statement
- Cookie Policy

Each page will display a “last updated” timestamp to maintain transparency and demonstrate the council’s commitment to keeping information current.

### **3.2.13 Multilingual support (English, Shona, Ndebele)**

To ensure inclusivity and broaden access, the website will incorporate multilingual and localisation features, allowing residents to view content in their preferred language. This functionality will be especially valuable in reaching rural communities and diverse audiences across Zimbabwe. The module will enable translation into local languages such as Shona and Ndebele, alongside English.

#### Key Requirements

- Header language selector
- Language preference stored via session/cookie
- SEO-friendly URLs:
  - /en/page
  - /sn/page
  - /nd/page
- Href lang tags for search engine optimisation
- Translation completeness tracking
- Supported Languages (Initial Phase)
  - English
  - Shona
  - Ndebele

The database design will utilise translation tables rather than hard-coded duplication, ensuring scalability and efficient management of multilingual content.

### **3.2.14 Monitoring & Evaluation dashboard**

To assess performance and improve service delivery, the website will include a monitoring and evaluation system that tracks overall usage and engagement. This module will capture key metrics such as:

- Total visitors
- Page views
- Document downloads
- Tender views
- Vacancy views
- News engagement
- Frequency of content updates
- Portal referral tracking

By collecting and analysing these indicators, the council will be able to measure the effectiveness of its digital platforms, identify areas for improvement, and ensure that residents are actively engaging with the information provided.

### **3.2.15 Audit logging and performance monitoring**

To uphold accountability and ensure a reliable audit trail, the website will include a logging mechanism that records all administrative actions. Every change made by an administrator will be captured, either in the database or in secure log files, along with the exact time the action was performed.

### **3.2.16 Performance Monitoring**

To ensure reliability and simplify ongoing maintenance, the website will include a performance monitoring system that continuously tracks operational health. This module will be able to:

- Monitor uptime
- Log system errors
- Generate monthly performance reports
- Alert the administrator in the event of downtime

By implementing these features, the council can proactively identify issues, maintain service availability, and ensure the platform remains stable and responsive for residents.

## **3.3 Security and Compliance**

- Implement HTTPS and SSL/TLS encryption
- Ensure protection against SQL injection, XSS, CSRF
- Implement secure authentication and session management
- Ensure compliance with data protection law Zimbabwe Cyber and Data Protection Act (2021).

### **3.3.1 Accessibility Compliance**

To ensure inclusivity and ease of use for all residents, the website will adhere to a comprehensive accessibility compliance policy. The system will incorporate features that align with international standards and provide flexible options for diverse user needs. Specifically, the website shall:

- Follow WCAG 2.1 Level AA guidelines
- Require alt text for all images
- Support full keyboard navigation
- Provide a font resize option
- Offer a high-contrast display mode

By implementing these measures, the council will guarantee that the platform remains user-friendly, accessible, and compliant with best practices in digital inclusivity.

### **3.3.2 SEO & Indexing**

To ensure the website is easily discoverable and accessible on the internet, strong search engine optimisation practices must be integrated into its design. The system will include:

- Automatic XML sitemap generation
- Robots.txt management
- Structured metadata schema
- Search index optimisation

By implementing these features, the council can improve visibility, enhance reach, and ensure that residents and stakeholders can quickly find relevant information online

### **3.3.3 Other features**

To ensure the website is easily discoverable and accessible on the internet, strong search engine optimisation practices must be integrated into its design. The system will include:

- Automatic XML sitemap generation
- Robots.txt management
- Open Graph tags for social sharing
- Structured metadata schema
- Search index optimisation

By implementing these features, the council can improve visibility, enhance reach, and ensure that residents and stakeholders can quickly find relevant information online

## **3.4 Testing and Deployment**

- Conduct system testing (functional, security, performance)
- Deploy system in a live environment
- Configure backups and disaster recovery mechanisms
- Provide guidance on website adoption strategies

## **3.5 Training and Capacity Building**

- Train council staff on:
  - Website content management
  - Basic website system administration
  - Data Protection and cyber security fundamentals
  - Ongoing system maintenance and updates

Seven (7) staff members including 2 ICT Personnel, 3 Human Resources personnel and 2 Finance Personnel are to be trained.

## **4. Methodology / Contribution to Output Indicators**

The assignment will adopt a phased implementation approach:

1. System design and planning
2. Website development
3. Testing and quality assurance
4. Deployment and rollout
5. Training and capacity building

The assignment contributes to the Specific Objective Indicator 3: In number of local authorities, the administrations and the elected councillors regularly informed their citizens about matters of the local authority.

## 5. Deliverables

| N0 | Deliverable                    | Number of Working days | Timeline | Place of performance | Comments                     |
|----|--------------------------------|------------------------|----------|----------------------|------------------------------|
| 1  | Inception meeting              | 1                      |          | Mutoko               | Design work plan             |
| 2  | Developed website              | 7                      |          | Zimbabwe             | Fully functional CMS         |
| 3  | Testing and Deployment         | 3                      |          | Zimbabwe             | Includes security validation |
| 4  | Training of staff              | 1                      |          | Mutoko               | Staff trained                |
| 5  | Final Report and Documentation | 3                      |          | Zimbabwe             | Technical + maintenance SOP  |

### 5.1 Travel Budget

The assignment will be undertaken in Zimbabwe with possible travel to Mutoko.

| Travel expenses                              | Number of experts | Number of days per expert | Comments                                                |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Per-diem allowance in country of assignment  |                   |                           |                                                         |
| Overnight allowance in country of assignment |                   |                           |                                                         |
| Travel costs (train, private vehicle)        | 1                 | 580km                     | Mileage for travel from Harare-Mutoko and Mutoko-Harare |

The reimbursement of daily allowance and overnight allowance will be made as lump sum per unit based on the following regulation:

[https://www.bundesfinanzministerium.de/Content/DE/Downloads/BMF\\_Schreiben/Steuerarten/Lohnsteuer/2024-12-02-steuerliche-behandlung-reisekosten-2025.pdf?\\_\\_blob=publicationFile&v=12](https://www.bundesfinanzministerium.de/Content/DE/Downloads/BMF_Schreiben/Steuerarten/Lohnsteuer/2024-12-02-steuerliche-behandlung-reisekosten-2025.pdf?__blob=publicationFile&v=12)

Other costs (e.g., visa, taxi), will have to be estimated by the expert and approved by the GFA pool manager before the trip and will be reimbursed against evidence. Pure travel time shall not be remunerated. Travel costs and ancillary travel costs (e.g. visa), will be refunded against evidence.

All travel activities must be agreed in advance with the responsible GIZ project officer and GFA pool manager of the project.

## 6. Duration of the Assignment

The assignment is expected to be conducted over **15 working days** between 10 September 2026 and 10 October 2026.

## 7. Reporting

The Short-Term Expert shall report to the GIZ/GFA Project Team

## 8. Qualification of the expert

|                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Qualification and skills | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Degree in computer science, Information Systems, Software Engineering or related field</li><li>• Strong knowledge of web development (PHP, MySQL)</li></ul> |
| General Experience       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Minimum 5 years of experience in web development</li><li>• Experience with public sector projects is an advantage</li></ul>                                 |
| Specific Experience      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Development of Content Management System-based website</li><li>• Knowledge of cybersecurity best practices</li></ul>                                        |

## 9. Assignment Location

The assignment will be conducted in Zimbabwe, with activities in Mutoko RDC.